all of the above. Over the next few months, India initiated and executed the largest evacuation exercise in the world called ‘Vande Bharat Mission’, which would go on to bring home 3.9 million stranded Indians between May and December 2020.

The prime minister, as people who work closely with him point out, frequently draws on his experiences from his role as the chief minister of Gujarat for over 12 years. This experience, almost always urges him to think of policy decisions from the perspective of states. He truly believes that states require autonomy in decision-making as well as financial independence to excel at governance. In his view, large-scale and major policy changes or actions don’t reach their potential without strong participation from the state governments. Also, deriving from his over four-term-long experience as the chief minister and one complete term as the prime minister, he had formed a strong opinion that *jan bhagidari* was crucial in ensuring success of our COVID-19 measures and for controlling the spread of the contagion. And without the state governments’ wholehearted participation, *jan bhagidari* could not be achieved. It would have to be local governments and regional authorities through whom information, schemes and containment measures would need to percolate. Therefore, as an attempt to take the state leadership on board, the prime minister, flanked by the Union health minister, the secretary of the MoHFW and Dr Bhargava of the ICMR, held the first of over 15 video conferences with chief ministers of all 28 states and eight UTs, apprising them of the efforts that the central government had been taking to respond to the COVID-19 crisis. He categorically asked the chief ministers to remain vigilant and strictly follow containment measures as the next three to four weeks were going to be absolutely vital in India’s fight against the virus.

The global and Indian media were constantly reporting coronavirus-related stories. In Italy, the grim situation of patients being denied treatment, convoys of trucks carrying coffins through Madrid’s empty streets and overflowing crematoria, and even visuals from New York of hotels being converted to quarantine centres were spine-chilling. Fear amongst the